

# Swanzey Financial & Governance Review

15 years of budgets, votes, and patterns — and where it's heading

Town of Swanzey, Cheshire County, New Hampshire

PublicLogic VAULT · Final Report · June 2026

# 1. Executive Summary

Across 15 years of official-ballot town meetings, Swanzey's electorate is consistent, legible, and increasingly stressed. Voters will fund operations but will not borrow; they reward saving and tax credits and punish bonds; their support for the operating budget is eroding; and they are actively restructuring how the town governs itself — all while the Town Administrator's office keeps turning over. The town is simultaneously taking on more (a water utility) and losing the executive continuity needed to deliver it.

## Headline figures

|                          |                                                  |
|--------------------------|--------------------------------------------------|
| <b>\$5.75M → \$8.94M</b> | operating budget, 2011 → 2025 (+55%)             |
| <b>≈ 6.7%/yr</b>         | recent growth (2021–2025)                        |
| <b>81% → 57%</b>         | operating-budget voter support, 2011 → 2025      |
| <b>\$47K (0.5%)</b>      | 2025 default-vs-proposed gap — the lever is gone |
| <b>2024 &amp; 2026</b>   | public works facility 3/5 votes — both failed    |
| <b>3</b>                 | town administrators in ~2 years                  |

## The recommendation in one line

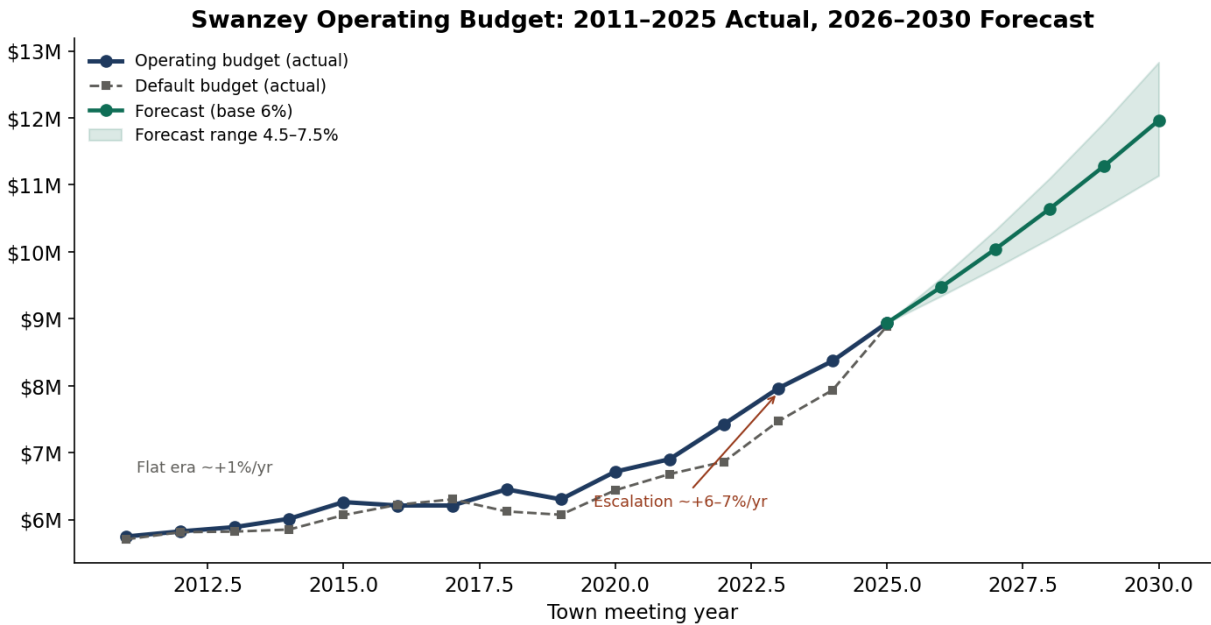
Stabilize the administrator, abandon bond-first capital for the reserve/state-aid/SRF strategy the electorate already rewards, and tell voters the truth about revaluation and the budget — in that order.

## 2. Findings

Provenance: [R-AR] Town of Swanzezy Annual Reports 2011–2025; [R-news] local news (2026); [D] derived; [M] modeled. Forecasts are scenarios.

### Finding 1 — Operating budget has entered a high-growth regime

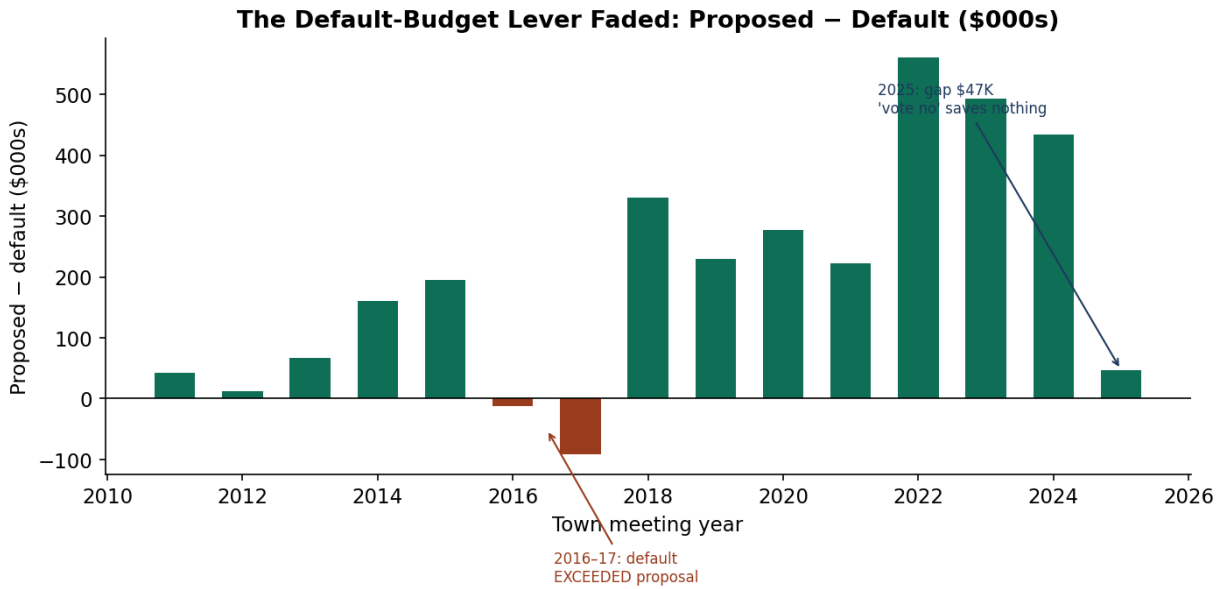
After a flat early-2010s (~+1%/yr), the budget shifted to +6–7%/yr (2020–2025), rising 55% to \$8.94M — driven by wages, health insurance, and the ambulance contract.



Source: Town of Swanzezy Annual Reports 2011–2025 (actual voted figures). Forecast modeled.

### Finding 2 — The default-budget lever has effectively disappeared

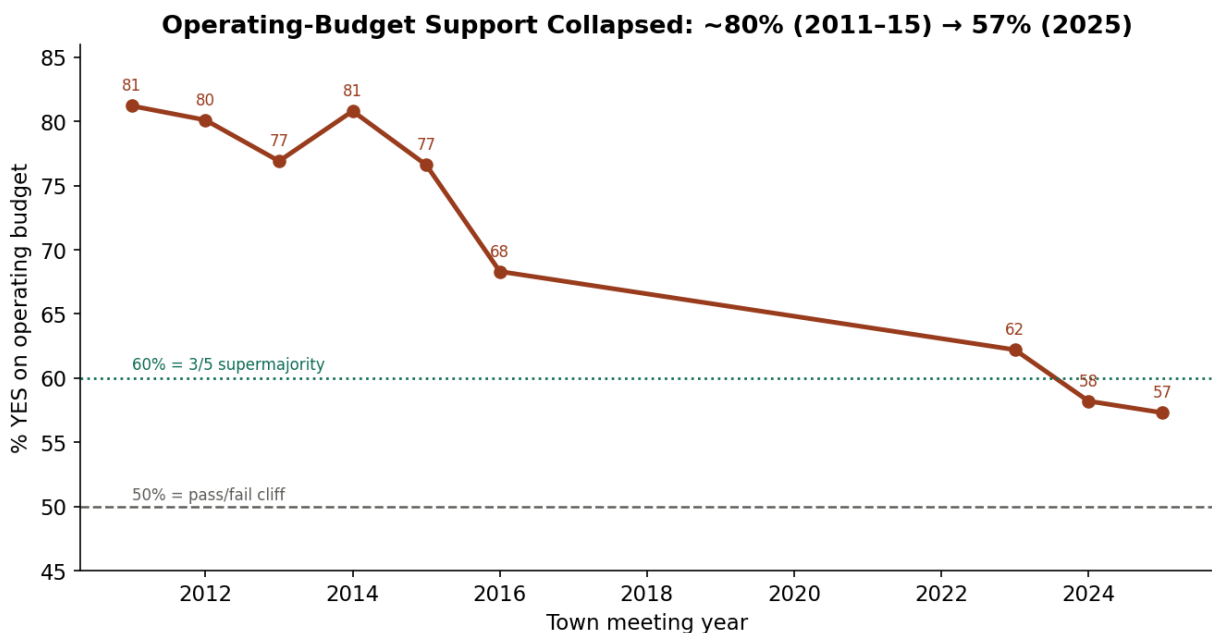
The proposed-vs-default gap collapsed from \$560K (2022) to \$47K (2025); in 2016–2017 the default exceeded the proposal. 'Vote no to save money' no longer works.



Bigger bar = more savings from rejecting the budget. Near zero by 2025. Source: Annual Reports.

### Finding 3 — Operating-budget support is eroding toward the 50% cliff

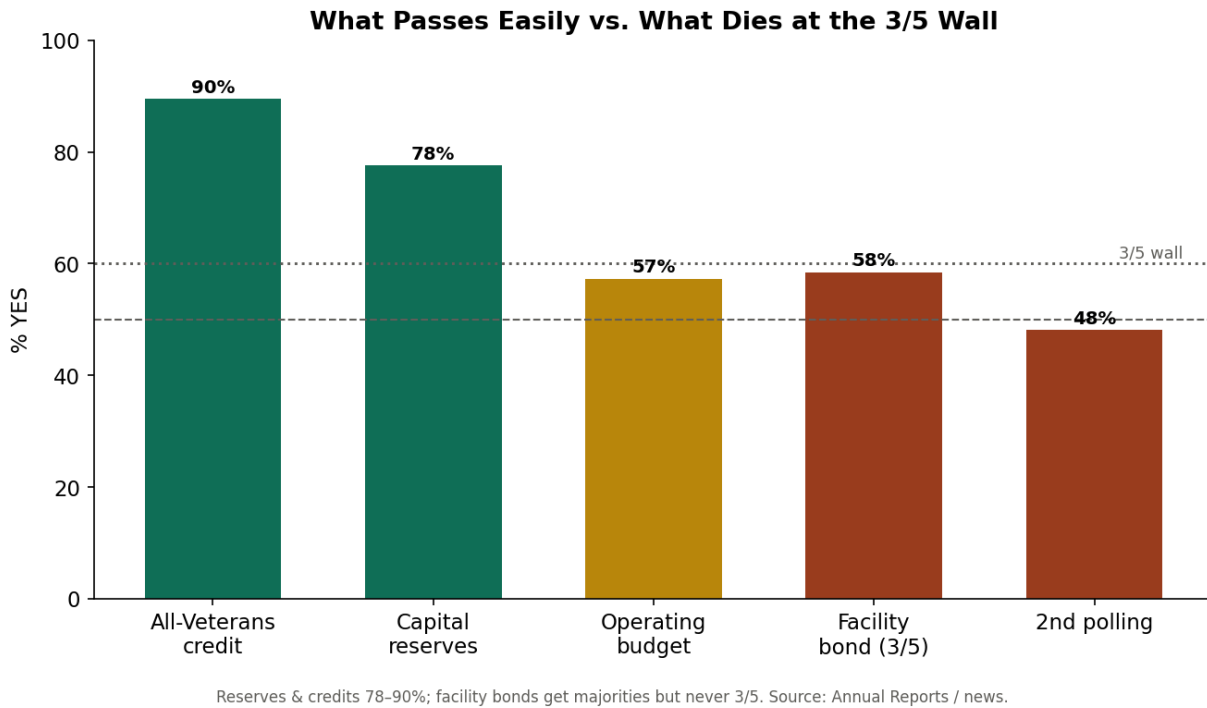
Approval fell from ~80% (2011–2015) to 57% (2025). A budget failure becomes plausible within a few cycles, though its fiscal impact would now be muted.



Source: Swanzev Annual Reports (years with machine-readable tallies).

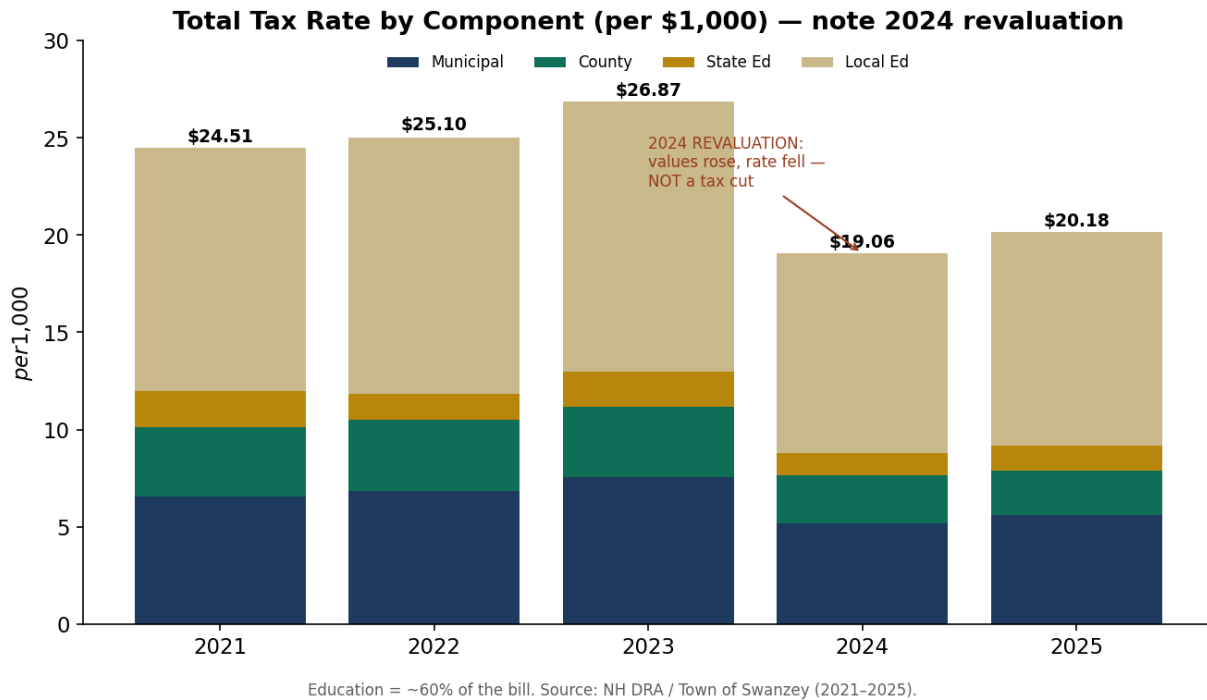
### Finding 4 — Capital paralysis at the 3/5 wall

Tax credits pass ~90% and reserves ~78%, but facility bonds get 55–58% — never the 3/5 a bond needs. The public works facility failed at 3/5 in 2024 and 2026. A threshold problem, not an opposition problem.



## Finding 5 — The 2024 rate decline was a revaluation, not a tax cut

Total rate moved \$26.87 (2023) → \$19.06 (2024) → \$20.18 (2025); the 2024 drop reflects higher assessed values, not lower bills. Education is ~60% of the bill.



## Finding 6 — Governance is being actively restructured

Voters expanded the Select Board 3→5 (2025, 740–653), rejected a second polling location (673–727), and kept SB2 (rejected repeal 345–809 in 2026) — overruling a board that had recommended repeal.

### **Finding 7 — Administrative instability is the master pain**

Three administrators in ~2 years (Branley → Torpey interim → Rautiola → open). Every other initiative restarts with each turnover.

### **Finding 8 — Development and land use are a live legal exposure**

The Avanru 74-unit senior-housing project drew a federal lawsuit alleging boards relied on opposition rather than zoning criteria; the Base Hill Road storage facility has been a multi-year dispute.

### **Finding 9 — The town is absorbing a water utility**

In 2025 voters authorized acquiring the West Swanzey water system (RSA 38:4), created a TIF district, appropriated \$3.5M and \$6.4M, and funded a study expecting '100% principal forgiveness' (NHDES DWSRF).

### **Finding 10 — Electoral volatility is rising**

Crowded fields, sub-30-vote margins, ousted incumbents, and recounts. Continuity is the scarcest resource.

### 3. Recommendations

Sequenced for impact.

#### **R1 — Stabilize the Town Administrator (first)**

Churn is the precondition pain. Offer a multi-year agreement with a written evaluation and a board–administrator delegation policy. (RSA 41)

#### **R2 — Reserve + state-aid + SRF capital**

Bonds die at 3/5; reserves and aid pass. Stand up capital reserve funds (majority vote), pursue 80% bridge aid (RSA 234) and DWSRF water financing. (RSA 35)

#### **R3 — Tell the truth on revaluation & the budget**

Publish a plain-language tax-bill explainer and a budget-driver brief. (RSA 21-J, 76)

#### **R4 — Publish a six-year CIP annually**

Convert surprise capital into expected line items. (RSA 674:5–8)

#### **R5 — Govern the new five-member board**

Adopt operating norms and onboarding. (RSA 41:8, 91-A, 31:39-a)

#### **R6 — Run water as an enterprise**

Rate study + asset-management plan; DWSRF repaid by rates. (RSA 38)

#### **R7 — De-risk land-use decisions**

Decide strictly on written criteria, with counsel. (RSA 672–677)

#### **Sequencing**

R1 is the keystone. R2 and R4 unlock the capital backlog the electorate keeps blocking. R3 rebuilds the trust R2's votes require. R5–R7 protect the institution while the rest takes hold.

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